

Left leaders go along with the joint panel but their objections to operationalising the nuclear deal could put the UPA in a bind



tence, many Left leaders used to view Sonia as the great unifier. One interpretation of her isolation from the discourse could be that she trusted family loyalist Mukherjee to win over the comrades in the impending war of nerves once the joint panel is formed. The other could be that she feels the agreement would help India's long-term energy requirements and thus is supportive of Manmohan. The more disturbing possibility could be that she could not fathom a way out of the crisis without a major compromise.

Mukherjee's political acumen and diplomatic skills will be required more than ever as the joint committee starts its deliberations. He has already created a congenial environment for the four Left parties to talk to him. This was possibly the only occasion in three

BACKROOM NEGOTIATORS:
(clockwise from extreme left)
Yechury, Karat, Bardhan, Patel,
Mukherjee and Antony

trying to gauge if subtle differences existed among Left Front parties on the topic. It is a sign of the Congress being on the defensive that he was trying to humour even the smaller Left constituents—the RSP and Forward Bloc. With the Congress-led alliance still insecure about the Government's tenure, Mukherjee might have thought it wise to keep all options open. Unlike the other three Left parties, the RSP had rejected the idea of a joint committee. "What is the need for a committee when we are opposed to the deal? What if our differences persist even in the panel?" RSP Secretary Abani Roy had questioned Mukherjee. Later, Roy clarified, "The CPI(M), CPI and Forward Bloc are conveying the same feeling indirectly."

Defence Minister A.K. Antony and Sonia's political secretary Ahmad Patel are Mukherjee's support team in formulating the composition and terms of reference of the joint committee. Till

IN A MAJOR CONCESSION FROM THE GOVERNMENT ON THE NUCLEAR NEGOTIATIONS



ATTEMPTS TO ALLAY THE LEFT'S APPREHENSIONS WAS A CASE OF TOO LITTLE TOO LATE

brink by the Left almost two weeks ago but Sonia has kept mum. Her silence has been questioned not just by observers in the media but also by Karat and his CPI counterpart A.B. Bardhan. Interestingly, till the nuclear stand-off threatened the UPA's exis-

years of the Congress-Left engagement where the Congress leadership actually bothered to hear out the Left constituents through four separate meetings. By inviting CPI(M), CPI, Forward Bloc and RSP leaders for individual discussions, Mukherjee was

last week, the Congress was confident that a political faction which refuses to acknowledge emerging geopolitics cannot overturn an executive decision even within the framework of a multi-party rule. The Congress has dealt with the Left's symbolic opposition to its